THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Grade 2

One step on each page: a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. The last room trains your ears.

THE ROOMS

1 · Major, minor and perfect

2 · Triplets, upbeats and pauses

3 · Finding the key

4 · The pedals

5 · Chords in a key

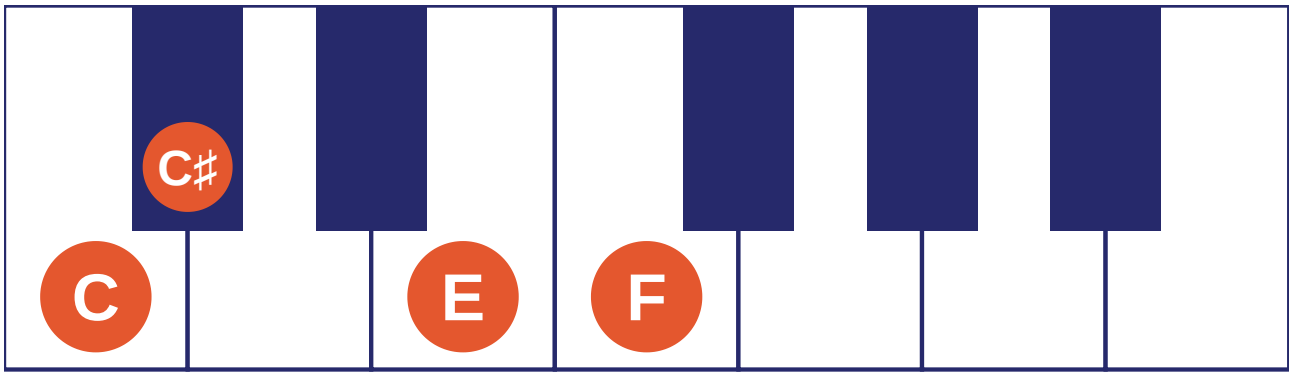
6 · Motifs and phrases

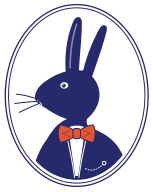
7 · Ear training

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 3

Major, minor and perfect

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **semitone** is the very next key, black or white. C to C sharp is a semitone. So are E to F and B to C: no key between.

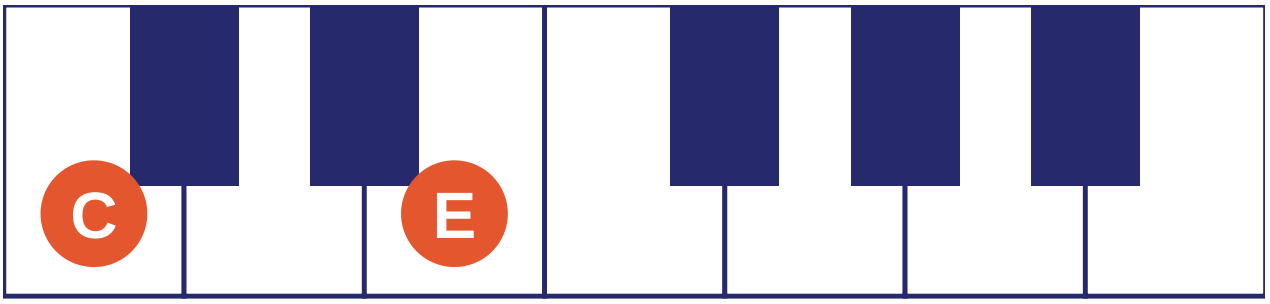
A **tone** is two semitones: C to D, or E to F sharp.

Try it at the piano

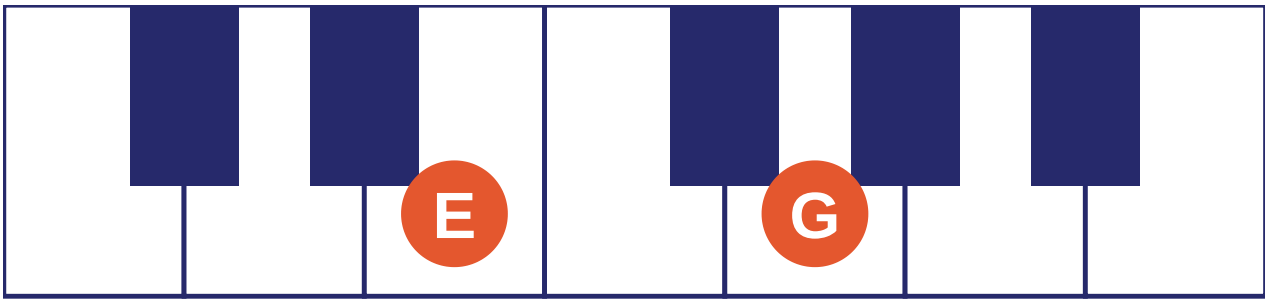
1. Play C, C sharp, D, one semitone at a time. Then C to D in one jump: a tone.

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 3

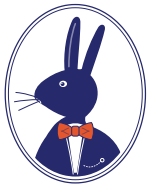
Major, minor and perfect



major 3rd · C to E · four semitones



minor 3rd · E to G · three semitones



Every 3rd skips one letter, but they are not all the same size. Count the semitones: count the steps, not the key you start on.

Four semitones make a **major 3rd**, bright. Three make a **minor 3rd**, darker. A major triad has a major 3rd at the bottom.

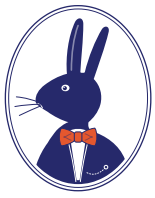
Try it at the piano

1. Play C–E, then E–G. Count the semitones of each with one finger, key by key.

ROOM 1 · STEP 3 OF 3

Major, minor and perfect

4th	5th	8ve
perfect 4th	**perfect 5th**	**octave (8ve)**
C to F	C to G	C to the next C



The 4th, the 5th and the octave are called **perfect**. They sound open and strong.

2nds and 3rds come in two sizes, **major** and **minor**: a major 2nd is a tone, a minor 2nd a semitone.

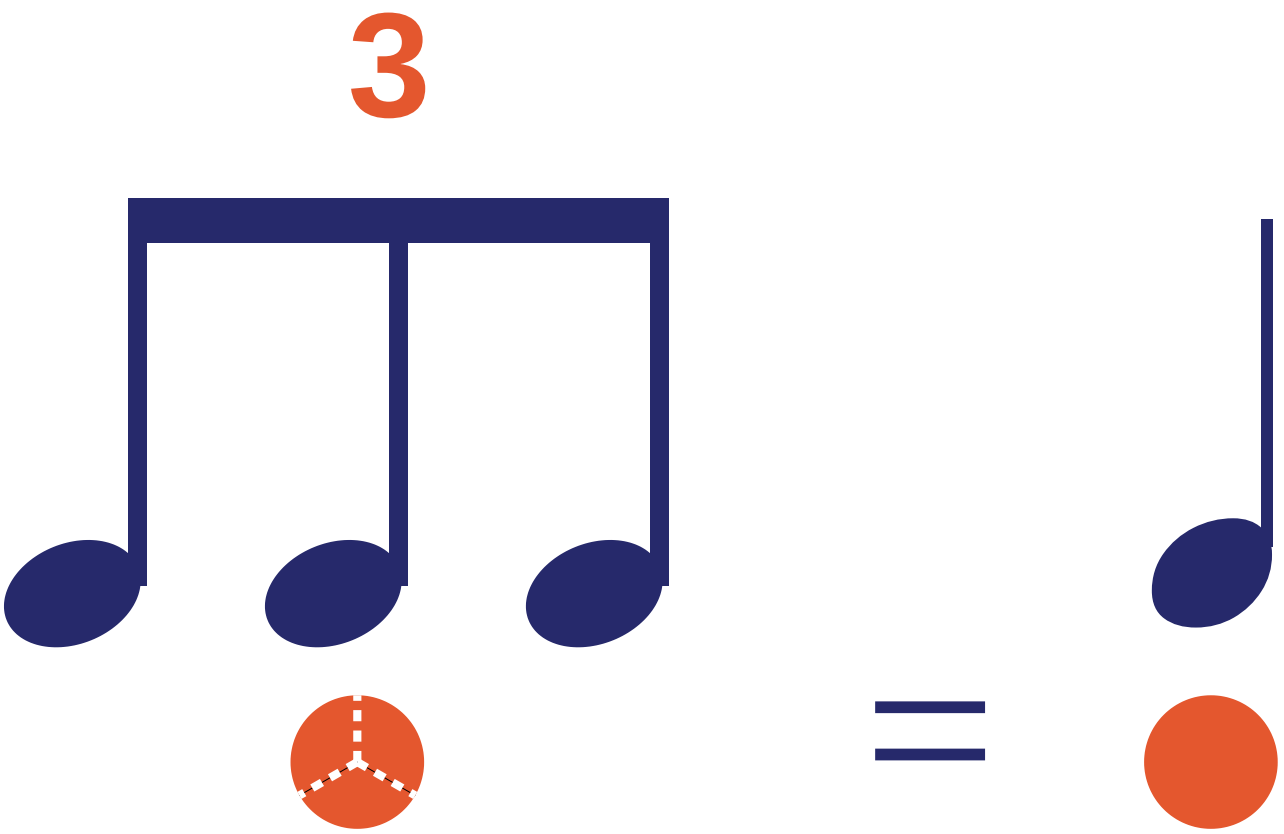
Try it at the piano

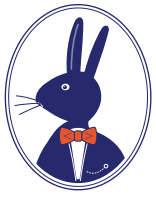
1. Play C–F, C–G and C up to the next C. Then play C–D (a major 2nd) and E–F (a minor 2nd).

ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

Triplets, upbeats and pauses

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **triplet** fits **three** quavers into the time of two. A small **3** over the beam tells you.

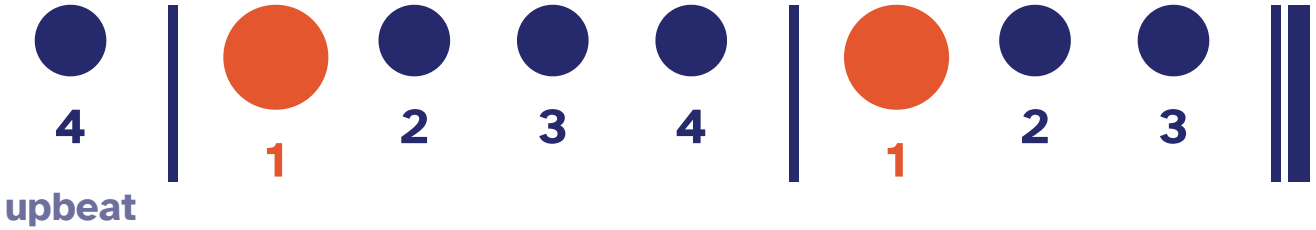
The circle is cut in three. Count it **trip-o-let** on one beat.

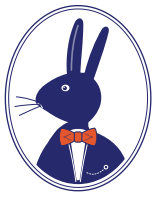
Try it

1. Clap four steady beats. Then clap three even claps on each beat, saying trip-o-let.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3

Triplets, upbeats and pauses





Some tunes start **before** beat 1. The note or notes before the first full bar are the **upbeat**.

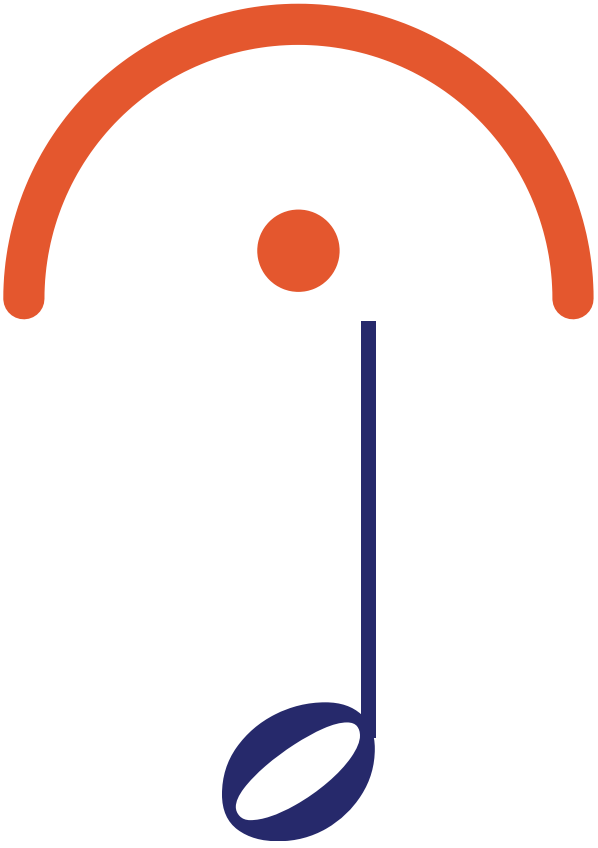
The last bar is short: it gives back the beat the upbeat borrowed.

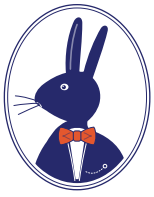
Try it

1. Sing Happy Birthday: “Hap-py” is the upbeat, and “birth” lands on beat 1. Clap the strong beat as you sing.

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3

Triplets, upbeats and pauses





An arch with a dot over a note is a **pause**. Hold the note **longer** than its value, as long as feels right.

Then go on with the steady beat again.

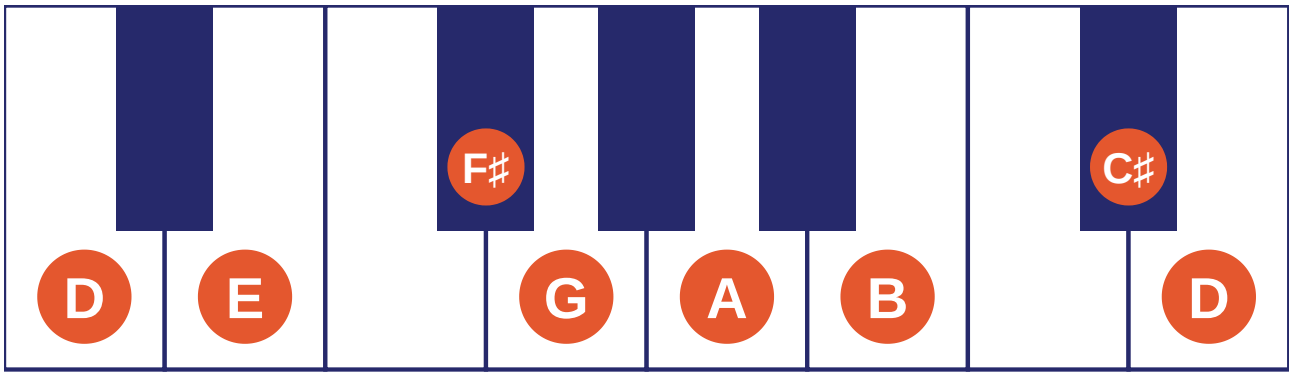
Try it at the piano

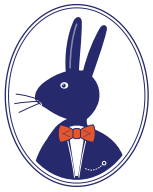
1 Play C D E F G, and hold the G with a pause. Hold it, listen, then go on.

ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 6

Finding the key

SCAN TO LISTEN





D major starts the scale ladder on D. To keep the close steps at 3–4 and 7–8, it needs **two sharps**: F♯ and C♯.

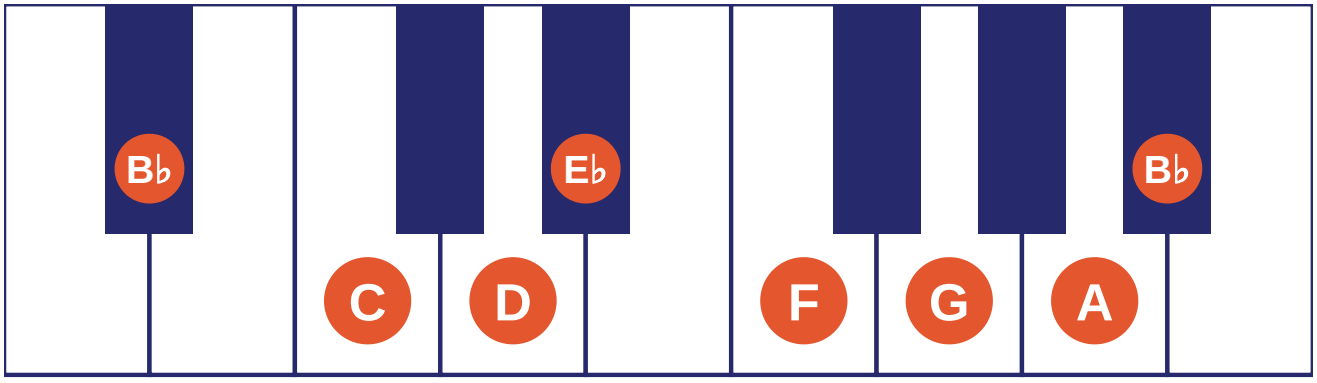
The fingers are the same as C major.

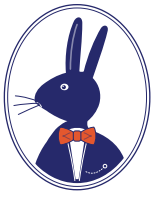
Try it at the piano

1. Play D major, right hand, two octaves: going up 1 2 3, 1 2 3 4, 1 2 3, 1 2 3 4 5; coming down the same numbers backwards.

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 6

Finding the key





B flat major starts on a black key. It has **two flats**: B♭ and E♭.

Its fingers are different: the thumb plays only the white keys **C** and **F**.

Try it at the piano

1. Right hand: finger 4 on every B flat, 3 on E flat, thumb on C and F: 4 1 2 3, 1 2 3 4. Two octaves up and down, slowly.

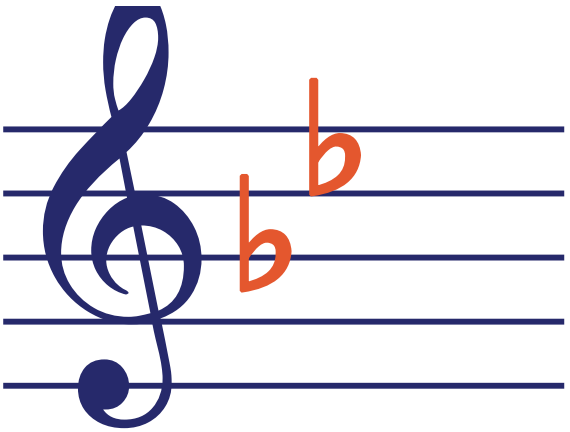
ROOM 3 · STEP 3 OF 6

Finding the key



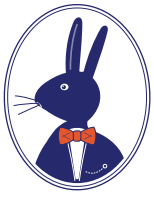
D major

F♯ and C♯



B♭ major

B♭ and E♭



The **sharps** always arrive in the same order: **F** first, then **C**. The **flats** too: **B** first, then **E**.

Two sharps: D major. Two flats: B flat major.

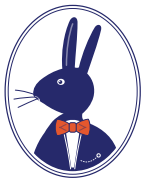
Try it at the piano

1. Look at the start of a piece. Count the sharps or flats and name the major key. ○

ROOM 3 · STEP 4 OF 6

Finding the key

2 ♯	2 ♭
D major or B minor	**B♭ major or G minor**



Every key signature belongs to **two keys**: a major key and the minor key that starts **three semitones below** it. Two sharps: D major or **B minor**. Two flats: B flat major or **G minor**.

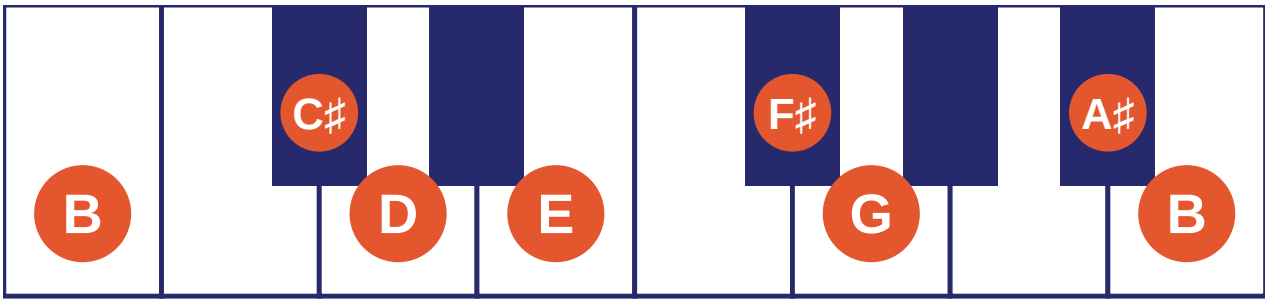
To tell which, look at the **last note**, and look for the minor key's raised 7th: A♯ in B minor, F♯ in G minor.

Try it

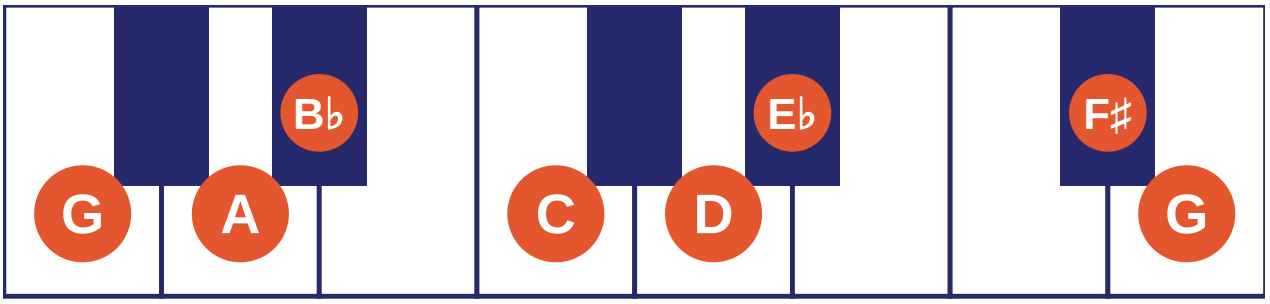
1. Find a piece with two sharps or two flats. Look at the last bass note. Major or minor?

ROOM 3 · STEP 5 OF 6

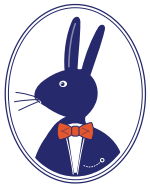
Finding the key



B harmonic minor



G harmonic minor



B minor keeps D major's F♯ and C♯. **G minor** keeps B flat major's B♭ and E♭. For the harmonic minor, raise the 7th by one key: **A♯** in B minor, **F♯** in G minor.

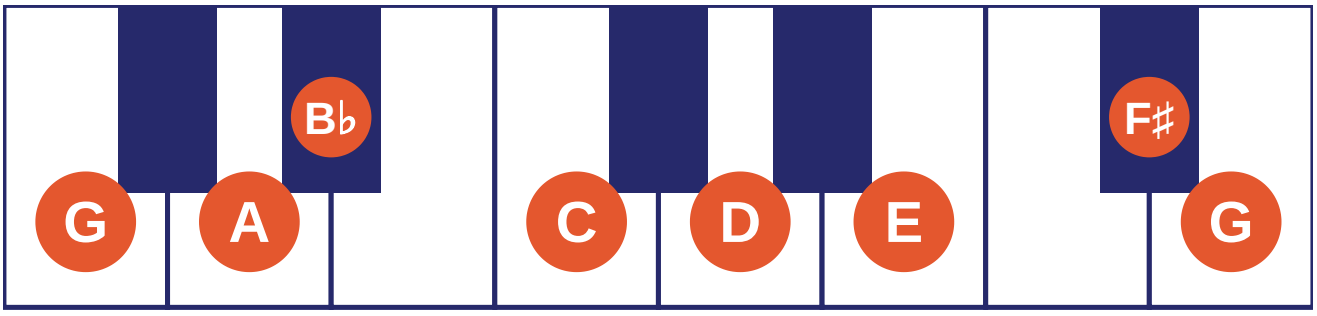
Both use the same fingers as C major.

Try it at the piano

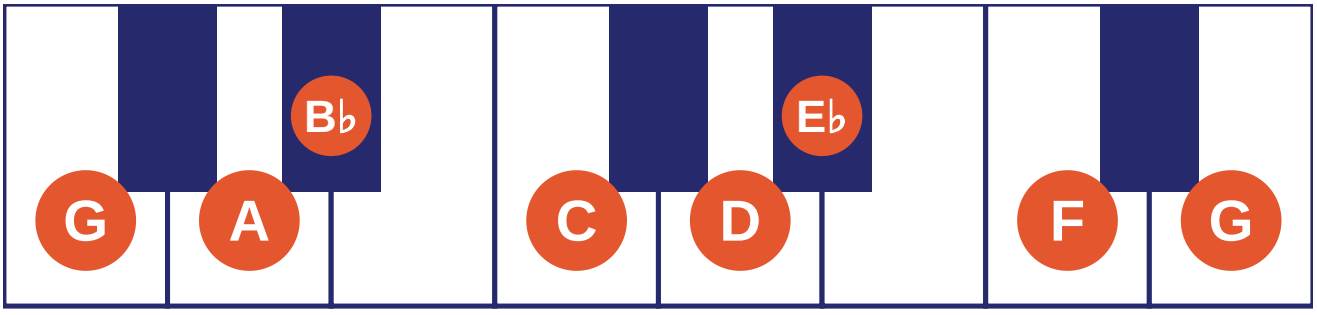
1 Play B natural minor, then B harmonic minor. Then G natural minor, then G harmonic minor.

ROOM 3 · STEP 6 OF 6

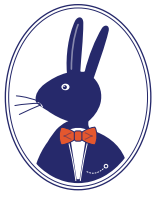
Finding the key



G melodic minor · going up



G melodic minor · coming down



A minor scale has a third form, the **melodic minor**. Going **up**, raise the **6th** and the **7th**: in G minor, E and F♯.

Coming **down**, it plays the natural minor: F and E♭ again.

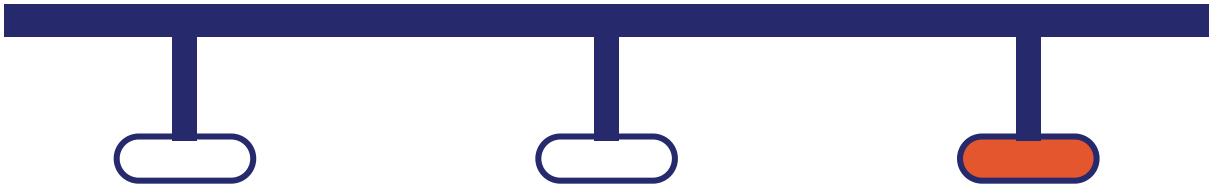
Try it at the piano

1. Play G melodic minor up and down, slowly. Listen to how smooth the top of the scale sounds going up. ○

ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 2

The pedals

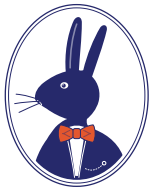
SCAN TO LISTEN



left
softer

middle
not on every piano

right
keeps it ringing



A piano has two or three **pedals**. The **right** one is the **sustaining pedal**: it keeps the strings ringing after you let go of the keys.

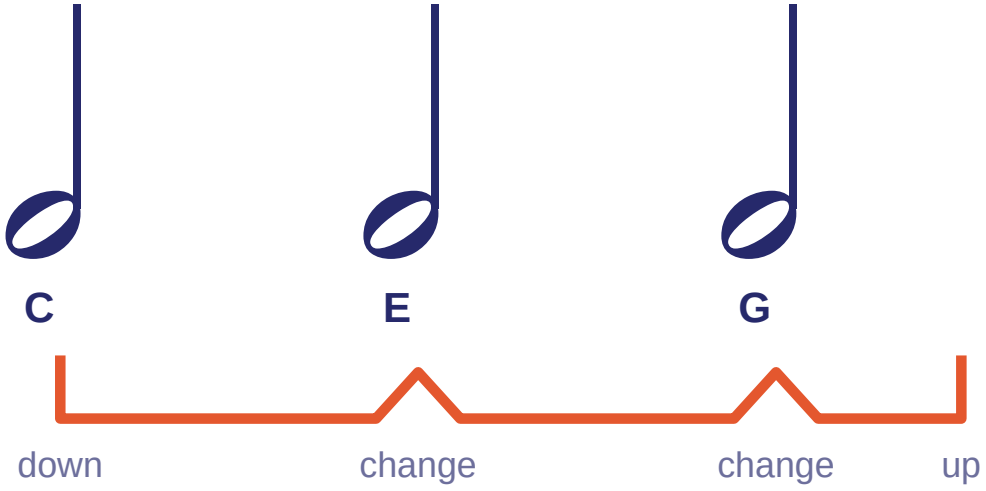
The **left** one makes the sound softer.

Try it at the piano

1. Press the right pedal, play a low C, and let go of the key. Listen. Then lift your foot.

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 2

The pedals





Keep your **heel on the floor** and press with the ball of your foot. For smooth pedalling, play the new note **first**, then lift the pedal and press it down again straight away.

The line under the music shows it. Each peak is a **change**. Some music writes **Ped.** to press and ✱ to lift.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C, E and G as minims. Press the pedal just after C. Change it just after E and just after G: up-down. Lift at the end. ○

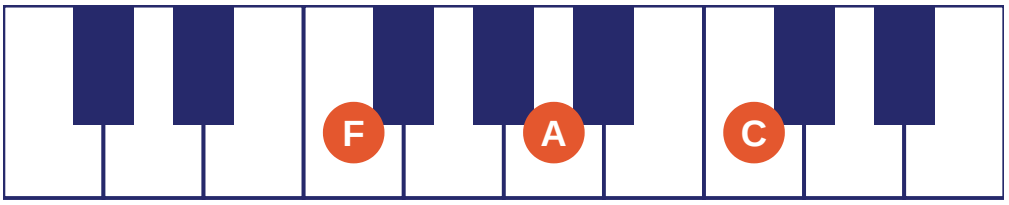
ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 2

Chords in a key

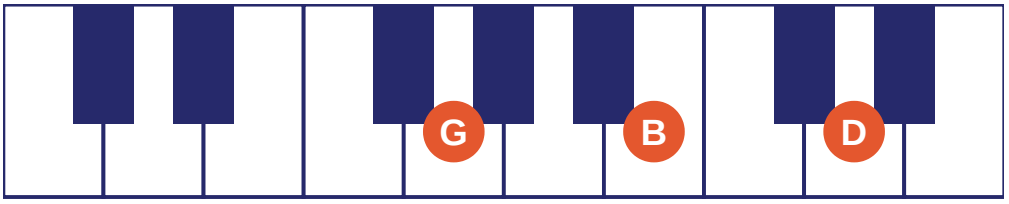
SCAN TO LISTEN



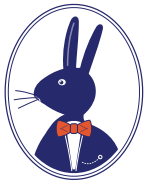
I · C E G



IV · F A C



V · G B D



Build a triad on every note of the scale and number them with **Roman numerals**: I, II, III, IV, V, VI, VII.

The three most important are **I**, **IV** and **V**. In C major they are C E G, F A C and G B D.

Try it at the piano

1. Play the three chords of C major: I, IV, V, then I again. Say the numbers as you play.

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 2

Chords in a key

V

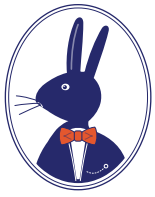
G B D

wants to go home

I

C E G

home



Chord **V** leans towards chord **I**. Play V then I and the music sounds **finished**.

In G major the same chords are G B D (I), C E G (IV) and D F♯ A (V).

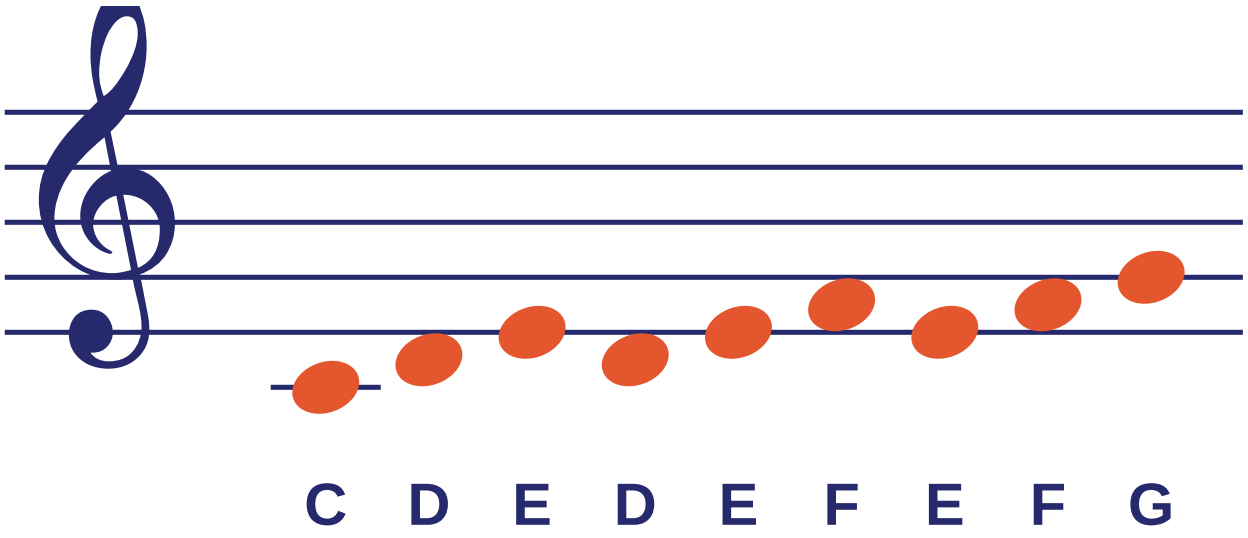
Try it at the piano

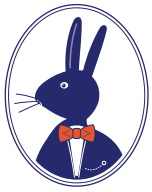
1. Play V then I in C major: G B D, then C E G. Then try it in G major: D F sharp A, then G B D.

ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 2

Motifs and phrases

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **motif** is a short idea, just a few notes. It comes back again and again, like a word in a story.

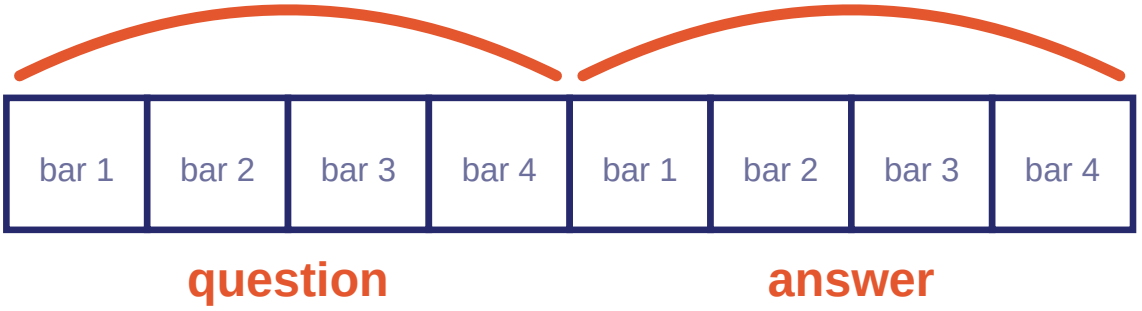
Here C D E comes back one step higher, and then again. A motif moved up or down like this is a **sequence**.

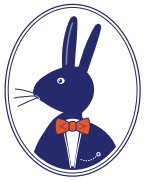
Try it at the piano

1 Play C D E, then D E F, then E F G. You have played one motif three times.

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 2

Motifs and phrases





A **phrase** is a musical sentence, often four bars long. At its end, the music takes a **breath**. A long curve over it is a **phrase mark**.

Two phrases often go together: the first asks a **question**, ending away from home; the second **answers**, ending on the home note.

Try it at the piano

1. Play four bars of your piece and lift your hand gently at the end, like a breath. Then play the next four bars: the answer.

ROOM 7 · LISTEN

Ear training

SCAN TO PLAY

1

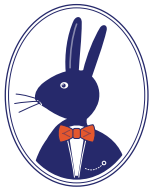
Clap it back

2

Sing it back

3

Two notes together: sing one



Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Three listening games belong to this level. Each one is in the app: scan the code and play one each day.

Try it at the piano

1 Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?